

Express View on Maharashtra midday meals: Not without egg

The Maharashtra government's **decision** to remove egg from its midday meal scheme a year after it was introduced, **ostensibly** for financial reasons, **seems** to place political **imperatives** over public-health **prudence**, especially since it **comes on the heels of** protests from right-wing groups against its inclusion. The state government had earlier allocated an annual budget of Rs 50 crore to provide eggs or bananas or a local fruit once a week to government school children to **combat** malnutrition. It later **amended** it to **state** that in schools where a sizeable number of parents protested against the inclusion of eggs, it would not be served. The new **directive cites** a finance issue in its **amendment** and has asked schools to **seek** public sponsorship should they wish to include eggs or sweets in the menu. In withdrawing egg pulao and rice kheer or nachani satva, a sweet dish, for students of Classes I to VIII, the Devendra Fadnavis-led government has joined a list of BJP-ruled states that do not provide eggs in midday meals. Only three BJP-ruled **states** — Uttarakhand, Odisha and Assam — **still** do. The decision in Maharashtra shows a **callous disregard** for the already **alarming** rates of **malnutrition** among schoolchildren from economically disadvantaged backgrounds by a government that has returned to power with an **overwhelming mandate**.

According to the National Family Health Survey (NFHS), child malnutrition remains a significant challenge in India, with data **pointing to** alarming levels of undernutrition, **stunting**, and **wasting**. NFHS-V (2019-21) reported that 35.5 per cent of children under the age of five in India were **stunted** (low height for age), while 19.3 per cent were **wasted** (low weight for height). In Maharashtra's Dhule and Chandrapur, districts in the bottom 10 across India in wasting, the numbers stood at 38.9 and 38.5 respectively. In Nandurbar to the northwest of the state, 57.2 per cent of children under the age of five were underweight, second only to Pashchimi Singhbhum in Jharkhand. These figures indicate the deep-rooted nutritional deficiencies many children face, particularly in rural areas. The data also **highlights** the critical role of protein in **addressing** these **deficiencies**. Compared to pulses, milk or even fruits such as bananas, eggs remain a more effective, **affordable** and easily accessible source of nutrition. The Maharashtra government has sought to replace eggs with alternatives like chickpea and soybean but the substitution ignores the logistical challenges of providing these at scale. By removing eggs, it risks **exacerbating** the nutritional gap.

Food choices are **inextricably** tied to questions of caste and religious identity and to **privilege**. Over the last **decade**, **protracted**, and often violent, **dissensions** over non-vegetarian food, be it over eggs or beef, **have propelled** the **myth** of India as a vegetarian nation. Before Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh had dropped eggs from its midday-meal menu. In 2022, Goa, too, briefly introduced and dropped eggs from its midday meal. According to NFHS-V data, however, 45.1 per cent women and 57.3 per cent men eat non-vegetarian food at least once a week. In a country struggling to deliver **nourishment** to its children, to **discriminate** on the basis of food can have **grave** consequences. The Maharashtra government must **reconsider** its decision.

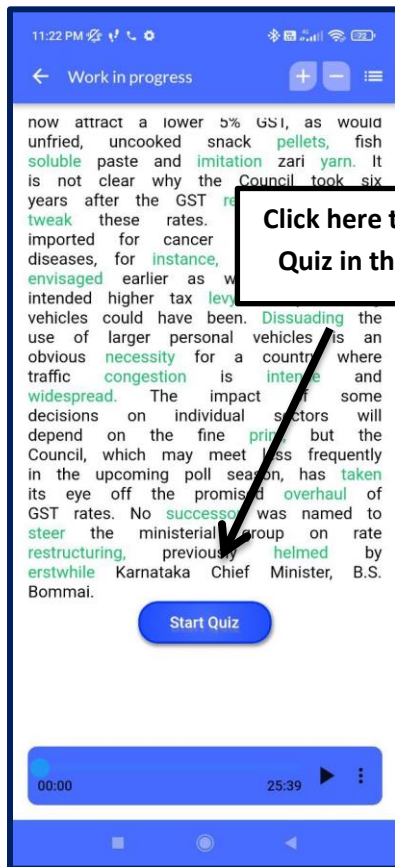
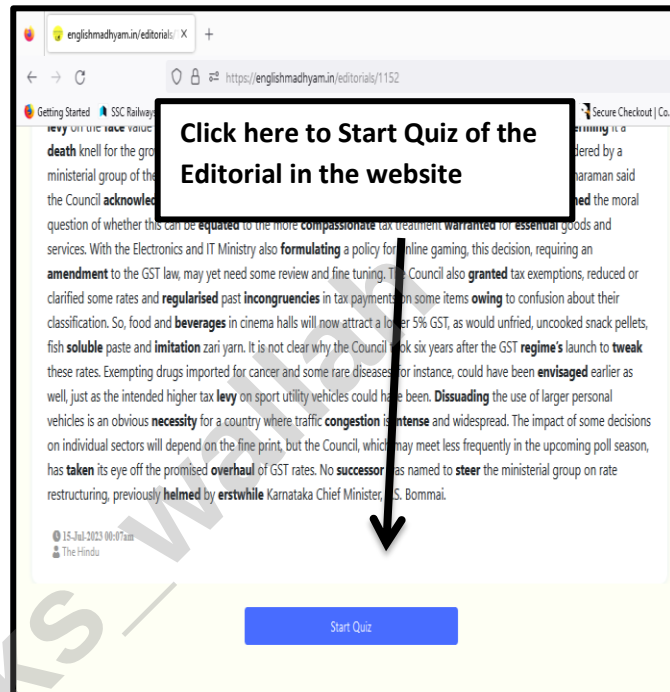
[Practice Exercise]

Vocabulary

1. **Ostensibly** (adverb) – Apparently, seemingly, outwardly, purportedly, allegedly प्रकट रूप से
2. **Imperative** (noun) – Necessity, requirement, obligation, essential, priority अत्यावश्यकता
3. **Prudence** (noun) – Caution, wisdom, carefulness, foresight, discretion बुद्धिमानी
4. **Come on the heels of** (phrase) – Follow closely, occur soon after, happen immediately after के तुरंत बाद होना
5. **Combat** (verb) – Fight, battle, counter, resist, tackle सामना करना
6. **Amend** (verb) – Modify, revise, alter, adjust, rectify संशोधित करना
7. **State** (verb) – Declare, express, mention, specify, assert कहना
8. **Directive** (noun) – Order, instruction, command, guideline, mandate निर्देश
9. **Cite** (verb) – Mention, refer to, quote, bring up, highlight हवाला देना
10. **Amendment** (noun) – Modification, change, revision, correction, rectification संशोधन
11. **Seek** (verb) – Look for, search for, pursue, strive for, attempt प्रयास करना
12. **Callous** (adjective) – Heartless, insensitive, unfeeling, indifferent, ruthless निर्दयी
13. **Disregard** (noun) – Neglect, indifference, ignorance, negligence, disrespect उपेक्षा
14. **Alarming** (adjective) – Worrying, concerning, disturbing, shocking, unsettling चिंताजनक
15. **Overwhelming** (adjective) – Intense, excessive, overpowering, enormous, immense त्यधिक
16. **Mandate** (noun) – Authority, order, directive, command, authorization आदेश
17. **Point to** (phrasal verb) – Indicate, suggest, highlight, imply, refer to संकेत देना
18. **Stunting** (noun) – the impaired growth and development that children experience from poor nutrition, repeated infection, and inadequate psychosocial stimulation. कुपोषण के कारण वृद्धि अवरुद्ध होना
19. **Wasting** (noun) – A wasting disease or illness is one that causes somebody to gradually become weaker and thinner. शरीर का अत्यधिक वजन घटना, क्षीणता
20. **Stunt** (verb) – Hinder growth, inhibit development, retard progress, limit, suppress विकास रोकना
21. **Wasted** (adjective) – (of a person or a part of the body) weak or emaciated. कमजोर

22. **Deficiency** (noun) – Lack, shortage, insufficiency, inadequacy, scarcity कमी, अभाव
23. **Affordable** (adjective) – Economical, budget-friendly, reasonable, low-cost, inexpensive किफायती
24. **Exacerbate** (verb) – Worsen, aggravate, intensify, escalate, heighten गंभीर बनाना
25. **Inextricably** (adverb) – Unavoidably, inseparably, inevitably, closely linked अलग न हो सकने योग्य
26. **Privilege** (verb) – Favor, give advantage, benefit, prioritize विशेषाधिकार देना
27. **Decade** (noun) – Period of ten years दशक
28. **Protract** (verb) – Prolong, extend, delay, lengthen, drag out विलंब करना
29. **Propel** (verb) – Push forward, drive, accelerate, stimulate, boost आगे बढ़ाना
30. **Myth** (noun) – False belief, misconception, fiction, legend, fallacy गलत धारणा
31. **Nourishment** (noun) – Nutrition, sustenance, food, dietary support, healthful sustenance पोषण
32. **Discriminate** (verb) – Differentiate, distinguish, show bias, segregate, favor unfairly भेदभाव करना
33. **Grave** (adjective) – Serious, critical, severe, dire, alarming गंभीर
34. **Reconsider** (verb) – Reevaluate, review, rethink, reassess, revise पुनर्विचार करना
- **Highlight** (verb) – emphasize, stress, underline, spotlight, accentuate जोर देना
 - **Address** (verb) – Deal with, tackle, handle, confront, attend to समाधान करना
 - **Malnutrition** (noun) - undernourishment, malnourishment, undernutrition कुपोषण
 - **Dissension** (noun) - disagreement that leads to discord . कलह, मतभेद

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based

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